

KEY EVENTS

16TH–17TH CENTURY

■ **1543** Portuguese voyagers land in southern Japan and introduce the matchlock arquebus, which is quickly copied by Japanese craftsmen.

■ **1592** Korean admiral Yi Sun-sin inflicts a crushing defeat on Japanese naval forces at the Battle of Hansando, leading Japan to abandon its first invasion of Korea.

■ **1598** A second Japanese invasion of Korea fails, after fierce fighting on land, and naval defeats at Myongyang and Noryang.

■ **1600** Victory in the Battle of Sekigahara enables Tokugawa Ieyasu to take supreme power in Japan. He founds the Tokugawa shogunate.

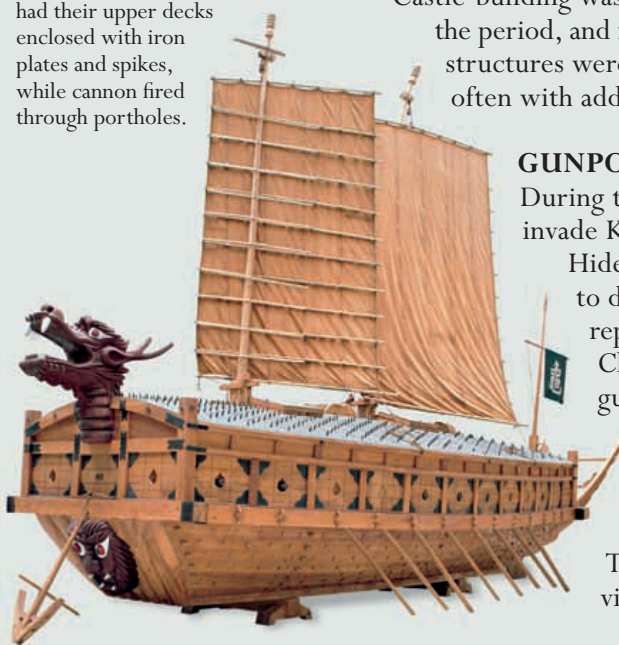
■ **c.1615** Jurchen warrior Nurhaci creates the Manchu Banner system, a military organization that proves highly effective against the Chinese.

■ **1644** Allowed passage through the Great Wall by a renegade Chinese general, the Manchu occupy Beijing and establish the Qing dynasty.

■ **1673–83** Emperor Kangxi of China defeats rebel warlords in the War of the Three Feudatories, and against Ming loyalists on Taiwan.

▼ A KOREAN TURTLE SHIP

Used against the Japanese in the 1590s, Korea's turtle ships had their upper decks enclosed with iron plates and spikes, while cannon fired through portholes.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

CONFLICT IN EAST ASIA

In the 16th and 17th centuries, a number of large-scale wars were fought throughout Japan, Korea, China, and southeast Asia. Many of these conflicts used innovative technology, including early gunpowder weapons and heavily armoured ironclad ships.

In Japan, the era from 1467 to 1615 is known as the Sengoku Period, “the age of the country at war”, during which powerful regional warlords, the *daimyo*, clashed regularly. The most ambitious of them – such as Oda Nobunaga and Toyotomi Hideyoshi – aspired to unite Japan under single rule, a goal eventually achieved by Tokugawa Ieyasu, founder of the long-lived Tokugawa shogunate.

THE SAMURAI AND THE ASHIGARU

The samurai warriors of the warlords' armies were shifting away from their origins as mounted archers, in favour of fighting on foot, using spears and swords. Their main sword was the two-handed *katana*, worn blade-upwards so that a samurai could draw it and deliver a cut in a single, sweeping movement. Although individual samurai became legendary for their fighting prowess, the peasant foot soldiers, the *ashigaru*, were also a notable force. After earlier experiments with Chinese firearms, from the 1540s onwards, the *ashigaru* adopted the European matchlock arquebus, which could be used to great effect by trained, disciplined squads. Castle-building was another important feature of the period, and many elaborate stone-and-wood structures were constructed at this time, often with additional outworks.

GUNPOWDER AND WARSHIPS

During the 1590s, Japan attempted to invade Korea twice, led by Toyotomi Hideyoshi. Chinese forces helped to defend Korea, and successfully repulsed the invaders. Korean and Chinese land forces had superior gunpowder weapons, typified by the Korean *hwacha*, a multiple rocket launcher capable of firing batches of a hundred incendiary rockets. The main reason for Korean victory, however, was their naval

prowess, which was at its peak in 1592–98, during which time Korean admiral Yi Sun-sin won a series of battles with a fleet of cannon-armed, oar-powered ships – the *panokseon* and the iron-armoured *kobukson* (turtle ships).

After 1615, the Tokugawa shogunate ended Japan's era of civil war; in China, however, the 17th century was still a period of major conflict. The Manchu, a federation of Jurchen tribes north



“As one man can defeat ten men, so can a thousand men defeat ten thousand”